arresting youth for speaking about it...this can trigger alienation," he says. Wangchuk's protest has now dovetailed with a remarkable joint struggle by the Leh Apex Body of Peoples Movement for Sixth Schedule (Apex) and the Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA), two otherwise ideologically and politically divergent organisations. The Buddhist-Muslim alliance has a four-point demand—full statehood, safeguards under the Sixth Schedule, job reservation and establishment of a public service commission, and raising the number of parliamentary constituencies to two from one.

On January 2, the home ministry set up a 17-member panel led by minister of state Nityanand Rai to discuss the protection of land and job rights and Ladakh's language and culture. Angered by the absence of their four-point agenda, the Apex-KDA alliance ignored it and, in a response on January 20, insisted on its inclusion. KDA member Sajjad Hussain Kargili of the influential Islamiya School in Kargil, named one of the panel's 17 members, says they are awaiting a response. After Ladakh was made a UT, says Kargili, people's problems have increased. "We have no representation. All decisions are taken by bureaucrats. We want our own assembly. Our youth are worried about their future. And there's a climate crisis unfolding," he says. The alliance is planning a protest at Delhi's Jantar Mantar on February 15, most likely with Wangchuk's support.

BJP Ladakh president Phunchok Stanzin says his party supports protection of the ecology and local rights, but the Sixth Schedule is not feasible. "The environment and the Sixth Schedule are not related. It has shortcomings and is not suitable for us. It was meant for the Northeast where a majority of land is forest-covered. LAHDC has powers on the pattern of Article 370 to protect land and ecology right now," Stanzin says. Citing the Rs 20,700 crore inter-state transmission system project for grid integration of 13GW renewable energy from Ladakh, he says: "No steps have been taken to destroy the environment."

Wangchuk, meanwhile, plans to fast for 10 days if his demands are not met and then increase its duration progressively: "After 10, I will fast for 15 days, then 20, and so on...till the government listens." ■

KARNATAKA/ ASSEMBLY POLL

VOKKALIGA PREMIER LEAGUE

By Ajay Sukumaran

Over the past couple of decades, the run-up to nearly every assembly election in Karnataka has involved a key question about the Janata Dal (Secular)—its ability to play the kingmaker. Such an outcome came about in 2004 and again in 2018, when the JD(S) was wedged in between the two bigger players, Congress and Bharatiya Janata Party, leading to short-lived coalition governments.

In these two decades, the reach of the party led by former prime minister H.D. Deve Gowda, anchored in support from the Vokkaliga caste group, has seemingly dwindled, with a regular exodus of leaders between elections. Yet, as Karnataka heads into another state election in April-May, that key question looms as large as it always has.

The prospect of a hung state assembly is something that both the ruling BJP and Congress are wary of, and keen to avoid. In the past few days, that concern was evident as top leaders of both parties trained their guns on the JD(S) as they toured the state.

At the BJP's *vijay sankalp* rally in the northern district of Belagavi on January 28, Union home minister Amit Shah dwelt on the two '*parivarwadi*' (family-controlled) parties in his address, saying that every vote to the JD(S) will eventually benefit the Congress. It was a line of attack against the regional party that Shah had first used a few weeks ago in Mandya—a stronghold of the JD(S) in southern Karnataka.

The Old Mysore region, which comprises around 10 southern districts, has been a difficult territory for the BJP to put down its roots. Here, the Vokkaligas—the state's second largest caste group, of which Deve Gowda is the tallest leader—form a significant part of the electorate. While the party

ANI



GOING ALL OUT
Union home minister Amit Shah with CM Basavaraj Bommai during a rally in Karnataka's Mandya, Dec. 30